

“A girl is no ... **better** for believing until her **marriage night** that **children are found** among the **cabbage leaves** in the garden.”

THE MARRIED WOMAN'S PRIVATE MEDICAL COMPANION, 1855

EXPERIENCES OF CONTRACEPTION

Family planning

Through history women and their sexual partners have tried to prevent unwanted pregnancies, and most types of contraception used today have long histories. However, the increased availability of reliable contraceptives and sex education proved revolutionary.



▲ Vaginal douche

Women used a douche to squirt water or spermicide into the vaginal cavity to prevent pregnancy, but it could not wash away sperm that had already reached the uterus.

THE MOST UNIVERSAL contraceptive method, across times and cultures, is probably *coitus interruptus* (also known as the withdrawal method), which was common in Europe, Africa, Australasia, the Middle East, and popular enough that both Jewish and Roman Catholic leaders spoke out against it.

Another similar method, which also required no foreplanning or extra materials, was *coitus obstructus*, which was noted in ancient Sanskrit texts. Hindus, meanwhile, were known to practice *coitus reservatus*. However, both of these methods were less common than *coitus interruptus*, likely because they were less comfortable for men.

As well as methods that put the onus on men, women throughout history have prevented pregnancy through the use of

barrier contraceptives. One of the earliest examples was the pessary, which was used to block the cervix or kill off sperm to prevent conception. There were numerous ancient recipes for pessaries—in ancient Egypt, these mixtures consisted of ingredients such as crocodile dung, honey, acacia, and lint, while ancient Greek women used siphium so much that the plant became extinct. Instructions in the Egyptian Ebers Papyrus (1550 BCE) suggests that women mixed concoctions themselves. Other types of pessary were more solid; plugs of chopped grass or cloth were used in Africa; bamboo paper was used in Japan; and some women used textiles such as wool (in Islamic and Greek societies), or linen

“**Self restraint** is the most **desirable** ... and **totally harmless** method.”

MAHATMA GANDHI, 1930

bags (popular among Slavic women). In modern times, devices have taken the form of Dutch caps and diaphragms.

One of the most common barrier methods to this day has been the condom. French cave paintings from 11,000 BCE show that a form of condom had existed long before they began to be manufactured from rubber in the 19th century. Historical condoms were less pleasant